

County didn't use broadest flood alerts

Local officials scrutinized for lack of notifications as waters rose in Texas

This article is by Joyce Sohyun Lee, Brianna Sacks, Aaron C. Davis, Scott Dance, Andrew Ba Tran and Imogen Piper

The Texas county where nearly 100 people were killed and more than 160 remain missing had the technology to turn every cell-phone in the river valley into a blaring alarm, but local officials did not do so before or during the early-morning hours of July 4 as river levels rose to record heights, inundating campsites and homes, a Washington Post examination found.

Kerr County officials, who have come under increasing scrutiny for their actions as the Guadalupe River began to flood, eventually sent text-message alerts that morning to residents who had registered to receive them, according to screenshots of the texts. But The Post's review of emergency notifications that night found that even as a federal meteorologist warned of deteriorating conditions and catastrophic risk, county officials did not activate a more powerful notification tool they had previously used to warn of potential flooding. The National Weather Service sent its own alerts through this system, beginning at 1:14 a.m. on July 4.

That mass notification system, known as the Integrated Public Alert & Warning System, or IP-SEE ALERTS ON A7



DANIELLE VILLASANA/ FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Gloria and Richard Rosales on Friday view a memorial in Kerrville, Texas, to victims of the recent Guadalupe River flash flooding.

In deluge's wake, talk of ending FEMA subsidies

White House explores retooling agency to stress states' post-disaster role

BY NATALIE ALLISON

For months, President Donald Trump and his homeland security secretary have said the Federal Emergency Management Agency could be eliminated. But as the president visited Texas to view

the impact of last week's deadly floods, administration officials said abolishing the agency outright is not on the agenda.

A senior White House official told The Washington Post that no official action is being taken to wind down FEMA, and that changes in the agency will probably amount to a "rebranding" that will emphasize state leaders' roles in disaster response.

The official and others emphasized that Trump will make the ultimate decision, but said at this point, FEMA is not set to be

abolished.

"Without any official action," the official said, "you're already seeing the theory" of the administration's new approach "taking place in Texas."

"The president immediately delivered the dollars, Texas already has that money in their hands, and Gov. [Greg] Abbott is the lead decision-maker when it comes to the Texas floods," the

President tours flood damage

Trump, first lady meet with families, first responders in Texas. A6

official said. "You should expect this structure, that has quietly taken place, to continue."

Trump on Friday met with first responders and family members of the victims in Texas, received a briefing from local elected officials and took part in a roundtable discussion. Abbott, a Republican, joined him during the visit.

Trump and Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem in recent months raised the prospect that the agency could be abolished altogether.

SEE FEMA ON A6

1,300 workers are fired at State

RUBIO CITES BLOAT FOR MASS LAYOFF

Diplomats say cuts will degrade U.S. soft power

BY JOHN HUDSON AND HANNAH NATANSON

The State Department began firing more than 1,300 employees via email on Friday as a part of the Trump administration's plans to downsize government and cut back on what it called "bloat" and inefficiencies. The move has come under criticism from current and former diplomats who say the cuts will degrade America's standing in the world and curb U.S. soft power.

The diplomats hit hardest hailed from the offices that Secretary of State Marco Rubio eliminated in his sweeping reorganization of the department, the most far-reaching in decades, including the Office of Global Women's Issues and the department's diversity and inclusion programs.

But cuts also affected employees working on highly volatile issues, including Syria, a brittle Middle Eastern country emerging from decades of authoritarian rule, and senior officials in charge of chemical weapons issues and

SEE LAYOFFS ON A4

Climate policy office closed

Remaining employees fired from Office of Global Change. A4

DAVID R. GERGEN 1942-2025

A towering insider in pillars of politics

BY ADAM BERNSTEIN

David R. Gergen, who helped craft and protect the image of four presidents as a senior White House communications adviser and who traveled the consummate political insider's path of high-profile jobs in punditry and academia, died July 10 at a retirement community in Lexington, Massachusetts. He was 83.

The cause was Lewy body dementia, a progressive brain disease, his son Christopher said.

A conservative-leaning centrist, Mr. Gergen was a ranking official in three Republican administrations (Nixon, Ford, Reagan) and one Democratic (Clinton). He held top editing posts at magazines including U.S. News & World Report, where he was also a columnist; spent decades as a respected political commentator on CNN, NPR and PBS; and had prominent jobs at the right-leaning American Enterprise Institute and the left-leaning Kennedy School of Government at Har-

vard University.

An institutionalist in an era of increasing distrust of institutions, the mild-mannered Mr. Gergen often used his media appearances to call for greater civility among those who enter public service. As early as 1994, he lamented the "breakdown of goodwill among elected politicians" and the character attacks and ad hominem ridicule that await someone entering public life in a media age that rewards

SEE GERGEN ON A8



PETER VAN AGTMAEL/MAGNUM PHOTOS FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The "Fight for America" interactive game has the audience move figurines around a model Capitol.

In London, Jan. 6 reenactment turns theatergoers into rioters and officers

BY KARLA ADAM

LONDON — In a city well known for political theater, the show at Stone Nest, a performance venue in the heart of London's West End, took the concept to a new level.

For the last month, audiences have been reenacting the events of Jan. 6, 2021, when a pro-Trump mob stormed the U.S. Capitol in one of the most violent and divisive days of modern American democracy.

Instead of sitting in stately

silence, crammed into velvet chairs, attendees at "Fight for America" were active participants — singing, chanting, rolling dice, and maneuvering tiny figurines around a model of the Capitol.

The unusual project — part tabletop strategy game, part thought-provoking political experiment — was meant to debut in the United States. But after President Donald Trump's election victory last fall, the team behind it pivoted to London.

"We thought maybe 3,000

miles away was the right way to start," said Christopher McElroen, artistic director at the American Vicarious, a Brooklyn-based arts nonprofit.

A Washington run is still planned for January to coincide with the fifth anniversary of the riot.

While the production might seem like a dark, even tasteless, parody, organizers said their hope was that by reenacting the history, participants might better understand how easily people

SEE JAN. 6 ON A12



DUSTIN FRANZ/ FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Aaron Zaliponi recounted the 2024 assassination attempt on Donald Trump in Pennsylvania.

He had Trump's would-be shooter in sight. Then he fired.

After a year out of the spotlight, officer Aaron Zaliponi tells his story

BY SHAWN BOBURG

ADAMS, PA. — As gunfire erupted at Donald Trump's campaign rally in Butler last July, Aaron Zaliponi glanced up and caught sight of the shooter's head and shoulders jutting above the peak of a rooftop about 115 yards away.

The Butler County SWAT team operator, standing in an open field between the gunman and the rally stage, snapped up his rifle, aligned the red dot of its scope with the shooter's chin and fired a single shot.

Would-be assassin Thomas Matthew Crooks immediately jerked to his right and slumped back from the roof's ridge, Zaliponi recalled, ending his volley of eight gunshots over five seconds that left Trump bloodied, one rallygoer dead and two seriously injured.

"I just got you," Zaliponi recalled thinking.

Zaliponi, a 46-year-old Army combat veteran, is

SEE ZALIPONI ON A9

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